



majority of the population." In Allahabad, nearly 400 young people turned up. Abhishek Shukla, who holds an MBA and LLB degree, said he came out of curiosity and to understand what Rahul wants from youth.

As his father Rajiv Gandhi did, Rahul has galvanised a significant number of young people into considering politics as an alternative. More important, he also seems to have a clear vision. The names of those short-listed will be submitted to the two AICC secretaries—Meenakshi Natarajan and K. Jitendra Singh—attached to Rahul. They would scrutinise the names and forward them to respective state presidents. Rahul would then have the final say in selecting the office-bearers.

The strategy is based on Rahul's discovery of India tours when he realised that the IYC was very weak at the grassroots level. Moreover, young people were disinterested. In November 2008, Rahul began his talent hunt.

**RAHUL AT AN IYC FUNCTION
AND (BELOW) CANDIDATES
BEING GRILLED IN LUCKNOW**

Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



medical graduates, two with PhD degrees and two management graduates besides an airline pilot. They belonged to both rural and urban middle class and many had no political background. Kamlesh Mishra, 22, with a B.Tech degree and currently working on a railway project, said, "I believe in Rahul's vision. He understands the aspiration of youth who constitute a ma-

Application forms were published in leading newspapers in key states inviting the youth to come for walk-in interviews. Over the next two months, he sat through many such interviews at his Tughlak Lane residence in Delhi to handpick at least 40 people who will make up the core think-tank of the IYC. He was assisted by IYC Chief Ashok Tanwar and Jitendra Singh. Four of the

handpicked leaders now head of the four zonal committees of Uttar Pradesh. Others were sent to different states or district units.

Simultaneously, he held organisational elections and introduced training programmes, a strict code of conduct and performance ratings. The organisational polls are based on the US presidential polls with elections at panchayat, block, assembly and state levels. The candidate who gets the most votes in each round is elected the state president. What is little known is that Rahul has created a separate 'election commission' within the organisation. This commission comprising four youth leaders—Manik Tagore, Vijendra Singhal, Prakash Joshi and Shakir Sanadi—works under the guidance of the Foundation for Advance Management of Election (FAME), set up by former chief election commissioners J.M. Lyngdoh and T.S. Krishnamurthy and K.J. Rao.

There have been setbacks: selected candidate lists were manipulated by senior Congress leaders in Bihar, others failed to perform when they were sent to the field while some had to step down as Congress leaders in the state protested. That, however, does not take away from the fact that Rahul's vision has credibility and he is using a corporate performance model. Whether it is the right model will only be known a few years down the line.

There is a precedent. Rahul's late uncle Sanjay Gandhi started in much the same fashion with the IYC. He attracted a new breed of youth leaders like Kamal Nath, Suresh Kalmadi, Anand Sharma, Akbar Ahmed, Ghulam Nabi Azad, Jagdish Tytler and Sanjay Singh among others. They were all urban middle class and relatively new to politics. They took the IYC to a new level and became the real stormtroopers of the Congress, leading to Indira Gandhi's famous remark: "They have stolen our thunder." That Sanjay misused the party when his back was to the wall during the Emergency is another story but if Rahul does succeed in his talent hunt, it may be another Mrs Gandhi who will be inspired to repeat that compliment. ■